

PSY403

Glossary

❖ **Acceptance**

Conformity that involves both acting and believing in accord with social pressure.

❖ **Actor-observer difference**

We observe others from a different perspective than we observe ourselves; in some experiments this has led to differing explanations for behavior.

❖ **Aggression**

Physical or verbal behavior intended to cause harm. In laboratory experiments, this might mean delivering electric shocks or saying something likely to hurt another's feelings.

❖ **Altruism**

A motive to increase another's welfare without conscious regard for one's self-interests; see also helping norms.

❖ **Arbitration**

Resolution of a conflict by a neutral third party who studies both sides and imposes a settlement.

❖ **Attitude**

A favorable or unfavorable evaluative reaction toward something or someone (often rooted in one's beliefs, and exhibited in one's feelings and intended behavior); see also prejudice.

❖ **Attitude inoculation**

Exposing people to weak attacks upon their attitudes so that they will have refutations available when stronger attacks come.

❖ **Attribution theory**

The theory of how people explain others' behavior; for example, by attributing it either to internal dispositions (enduring traits, motives, and attitudes) or to external situations.

❖ **Authoritarian personality**

A personality that is disposed to favor obedience to authority and intolerance of outgroups and those lower in status.

❖ **Benevolent sexism**

A seemingly favorable attitude that puts women on a pedestal but sometimes conveys an assumption that women need men's protection.

❖ **Bio-psycho-social**

The interplay of biological, psychological, and social influences.

❖ **Brainwashing**

Coercive persuasion that aims to change beliefs; see also compliance.

❖ **Bystander effect**

The finding that a person is less likely to provide help when there are other bystanders.

❖ **Central nervous system (CNS)**

The part of the nervous system consisting of the brain and spinal cord.

❖ **Cerebellum**

The region of the brain attached to the brain stem that controls motor coordination, posture, and balance as well as the ability to learn control of body movements.

❖ **Cerebral cortex**

The outer surface of the cerebrum.

❖ **Cerebral hemispheres**

The two halves of the cerebrum, connected by the corpus callosum.

❖ **Cerebrum**

The region of the brain that regulates higher cognitive and emotional functions.

❖ **Closure**

A perceptual organizing process that leads individuals to see incomplete figures as complete.

❖ **Cognitive dissonance**

Tension that arises when one is simultaneously aware of two inconsistent cognitions. For example, dissonance may occur when we realize that we have, with little justification, acted contrary to our attitudes or made a decision favoring one alternative despite reasons favoring another.

❖ **Cognitive map**

A mental representation of physical space.

❖ **Cohesiveness**

A "we feeling"; the extent to which members of a group are bound together, such as by attraction for one another factor in groupthink.

❖ **Collectivism**

Giving priority to the goals of one's groups (often one's extended family or work group) and defining one's identity accordingly.

❖ **Companionate love**

The affection we feel for those with whom our lives are deeply intertwined.

❖ **Compliance**

Conformity that involves publicly acting in accord with an implied or explicit request while privately disagreeing; see also brainwashing; foot-in-the-door phenomenon.

❖ **Confederate**

An accomplice of the experimenter.

❖ **Confirmation bias**

A tendency to search for information that confirms one's preconceptions.

❖ **Conflict**

A perceived incompatibility of actions or goals beliefs and judgments.

❖ **Conformity**

A change in behavior or belief as the result of real or imagined group pressure.

❖ **Consensus**

In attribution theory, the extent to which others act similarly to the person whose behavior is being explained attribution theory.

❖ **Consistency**

In attribution theory, the extent to which someone acts similarly on different occasions.

❖ **Corpus callosum**

The mass of nerve fibers connecting the two hemispheres of the cerebrum.

❖ **Correlational research**

The study of the naturally occurring relationships among variables.

❖ **Counterfactual thinking**

Imagining alternative scenarios and outcomes that might have happened but didn't.

❖ **Covariation principle**

A theory that suggests that people attribute a behavior to a causal factor if that factor was present whenever the behavior occurred but was absent whenever it did not occur.

❖ **Debriefing**

In social psychology, the postexperimental explanation of a study to its participants. Debriefing usually discloses any deception and often queries participants regarding their understandings and feelings.

❖ **Deception**

In research, an effect by which participants are misinformed or misled about the study's methods and purposes.

❖ **Deindividuation**

Loss of self-awareness and evaluation apprehension; occurs in group situations that foster responsiveness to group norms, good or bad.

❖ **Dependent variable**

The variable being measured, so called because it may depend on manipulations of the independent variable.

❖ **Descriptive statistics**

Statistical procedures that are used to summarize sets of scores with respect to central tendencies, variability, and correlations.

❖ **Discrimination**

Unjustified negative behavior toward a group or its members.

❖ **Displacement**

The redirection of aggression to a target other than the source of the frustration. Generally, the new target is a safer or more socially acceptable target.

❖ **Dispositional attribution**

Attributing behavior to the person's disposition and traits.

❖ **DSM-IV-TR**

The current diagnostic and statistical manual of the American Psychiatric Association that classifies, defines, and describes mental disorders.

❖ **Egoism**

A motive (supposedly underlying all behavior) to increase one's own welfare. The opposite of altruism, which aims to increase another's welfare effects of.

❖ **Empathy**

The vicarious experience of another's feelings; putting oneself in another's shoes enabling relationship.

❖ **False consensus effect**

The tendency to overestimate the commonality of one's opinions and one's undesirable or unsuccessful behaviors.

❖ **Frontal lobe**

Region of the brain located above the lateral fissure and in front of the central sulcus; involved in motor control and cognitive activities.

❖ **Frustration-aggression hypothesis**

According to this hypothesis, frustration occurs in situations in which people are prevented or blocked from attaining their goals; a rise in frustration then leads to a greater probability of aggression.

❖ **Fundamental attribution error**

The tendency for observers to underestimate situational influences and overestimate dispositional influences upon others' behavior. (Also called correspondence bias, because we so often see behavior as corresponding to a disposition).

❖ **Fundamental attribution error (FAE)**

The dual tendency of observers to underestimate the impact of situational factors and to overestimate the influence of dispositional factors on a person's behavior.

❖ **Group**

Two or more people who, for longer than a few moments, interact with and influence one another and perceive one another as "us".

❖ **Group dynamics**

The study of how group processes change individual functioning.

❖ **Group polarization**

Group-produced enhancement of members' preexisting tendencies; a strengthening of the members' average tendency, not a split within the group.

❖ **Group-serving bias**

Explaining away outgroup members' positive behaviors; also attributing negative behaviors to their dispositions (while excusing such behavior by one's own group).

❖ **Groupthink**

"The mode of thinking that persons engage in when concurrence-seeking becomes so dominant in a cohesive in-group that it tends to override realistic appraisal of alternative courses of action." Irving Janis (1971).

❖ **Heuristic**

A thinking strategy that enables quick, efficient judgments.

❖ **Hindsight bias**

The tendency to exaggerate, after learning an outcome, one's ability to have foreseen how something turned out. Also known as the I-knew-it-all-along phenomenon.

❖ **Hippocampus**

The part of the limbic system that is involved in the acquisition of explicit memory.

❖ **Homeostasis**

Constancy or equilibrium of the internal conditions of the body.

❖ **Hostile aggression**

Aggression driven by anger and performed as an end in itself. (also called affective aggression).

❖ **Hypothalamus**

The brain structure that regulates motivated behavior (such as eating and drinking) and homeostasis.

❖ **Hypothesis**

A tentative and testable explanation of the relationship between two (or more) events or variables; often stated as a prediction that a certain outcome will result from specific conditions.

❖ **Illusion**

An experience of a stimulus pattern in a manner that is demonstrably incorrect but shared by others in the same perceptual environment.

❖ **Illusory correlation**

Perception of a relationship where none exists, or perception of a stronger relationship than actually exists.

❖ **Individualism**

The concept of giving priority to one's own goals over group goals and defining one's identity in terms of personal attributes rather than group identifications.

❖ **Inductive reasoning**

A form of reasoning in which a conclusion is made about the probability of some state of affairs, based on the available evidence and past experience.

❖ **Informed consent**

An ethical principle requiring that research participants be told enough to enable them to choose whether they wish to participate.

❖ **Ingroup**

"Us"—a group of people who share a sense of belonging, a feeling of common identity.

❖ **Ingroup bias**

The tendency to favor one's own group cause of conflict.

❖ **Instrumental aggression**

Aggression that is a means to some other end.

❖ **Interaction**

A relationship in which the effect of one factor (such as biology) depends on another factor (such as environment) of biology and culture.

❖ **Just-world phenomenon**

The tendency of people to believe that the world is just and that people therefore get what they deserve and deserve what they get.

❖ **Leadership**

The process by which certain group members motivate and guide the group.

❖ **Learned helplessness**

The hopelessness and resignation learned when a human or an animal perceives no control over repeated bad events.

❖ **Longitudinal**

design A research design in which the same participants are observed repeatedly, sometimes over many years.

❖ **Medulla**

The region of the brain stem that regulates breathing, waking, and heartbeat.

❖ **Meta-analysis**

A statistical technique for evaluating hypotheses by providing a formal mechanism for detecting the general conclusions found in data from many different experiments.

❖ **Motor cortex**

The region of the cerebral cortex that controls the action of the body's voluntary muscles.

❖ **Observational learning**

The process of learning new responses by watching the behavior of another.

❖ **Observer bias**

The distortion of evidence because of the personal motives and expectations of the viewer.

❖ **Occipital lobe**

Rearmost region of the brain; contains primary visual -cortex.

❖ **Opponent-process theory**

The theory that all color experiences arise from three systems, each of which includes two “opponent” elements (red versus green, blue versus yellow, and black versus white).

❖ **Parietal lobe**

Region of the brain behind the frontal lobe and above the lateral fissure; contains somatosensory cortex.

❖ **Persuasion**

The process by which a message induces change in beliefs, attitudes, or behaviors.

❖ **Phi phenomenon**

The simplest form of apparent motion, the movement illusion in which one or more stationary lights going on and off in succession are perceived as a single moving light.

❖ **Prejudice**

A preconceived negative judgment of a group and its individual members.

❖ **Primacy effect**

Other things being equal, information presented first usually has the most influence.

❖ **Private self-awareness**

A psychological state in which one is aware of one's hidden private self-aspects.

❖ **Private self-consciousness**

The tendency to be aware of the covert, private aspects of the self.

❖ **Prosocial behavior**

Positive, constructive, helpful social behavior; the opposite of antisocial behavior.

❖ **Proximity**

Geographical nearness. Proximity (more precisely, "functional distance").

❖ **Public self-awareness**

A psychological state in which one is aware of one's public self-aspects

❖ **Public self-consciousness**

The tendency to be aware of the publicly displayed aspects of the self.

❖ **Racism**

Discrimination against people based on their skin color or ethnic heritage.

❖ **Recency effect**

Information presented last sometimes has the most influence. Recency effects are less common than primacy effects.

❖ **Sample**

A subset of a population selected as participants in an experiment.

❖ **Schema**

A concept or framework that organizes and interprets information.

❖ **Self**

A symbol-using individual who can reflect upon his/her own behavior.

❖ **Self-affirmation theory**

A theory that

- (a) people often experience a self-image threat, after engaging in an undesirable behavior; and that

(b) they can compensate by affirming another aspect of the self.

Threaten people's self-concept in one domain and they will compensate either by refocusing or by doing good deeds in some other domain.

❖ **Self-awareness**

A self-conscious state in which attention focuses on oneself. It makes people more sensitive to their own attitudes and dispositions deindividuation in groups.

❖ **Self-concept**

A person's answers to the question "Who am I?."

❖ **Self-disclosure**

Revealing intimate aspects of oneself to others.

❖ **Self-efficacy**

A sense that one is competent and effective, distinguished from self-esteem, one's sense of self-worth. A bombardier might feel high self-efficacy and low self-esteem.

❖ **Self-esteem**

A person's overall self-evaluation or sense of self-worth.

❖ **Self-fulfilling prophecy**

A belief that leads to its own fulfillment; behavioral confirmation.

❖ **Self-perception theory**

The theory that when we are unsure of our attitudes, we infer them much as would someone observing us, by looking at our behavior and the circumstances under which it occurs.

❖ **Self-schema**

Beliefs about self that organize and guide the processing of self-relevant information.

❖ **Self-serving attributions**

A form of self-serving bias; the tendency to attribute positive outcomes to oneself and negative outcomes to other factors.

❖ **Self-serving bias**

The tendency to perceive oneself favorably.

❖ **Situational attribution**

Attributing behavior to the environment

❖ **Social anxiety**

The unpleasant emotion people experience due to their concern with interpersonal evaluation

❖ **Social categorization**

The classification of people into groups based on their common attributes.

❖ **social cognition**

How and what we think about one another.

❖ **social comparison**

Evaluating one's abilities and opinions by comparing oneself with others attractiveness.

❖ **Social comparison theory**

The theory that proposes that we evaluate our thoughts and actions by comparing them to those of others.

❖ **social facilitation**

- (1) Original meaning: the tendency of people to perform simple or well-learned tasks better when others are present.
- (2) Current meaning: the strengthening of dominant (prevalent, likely) responses in the presence of others.

❖ **social identity**

The "we" aspect of our self-concept; the part of our answer to "Who am I?" that comes from our group memberships.

❖ **social learning theory**

The theory that we learn social behavior by observing and imitating and by being rewarded and punished.

❖ **social loafing**

The tendency for people to exert less effort when they pool their efforts toward a common goal than when they are individually accountable.

❖ **Social norms**

The expectation a group has for its members regarding acceptable and appropriate attitudes and behaviors.

❖ **Social perception**

The way we seek to know and understand other persons and events.

❖ **social psychology**

The scientific study of how people think about, influence, and relate to one another common sense.

❖ **social-exchange theory**

The theory that human interactions are transactions that aim to maximize one's rewards and minimize one's costs.

❖ **Socialization**

The lifelong process whereby an individual's behavioral patterns, values, standards, skills, attitudes, and motives are shaped to conform to those regarded as desirable in a particular society.

❖ **stereotype**

A belief about the personal attributes of a group of people. Stereotypes are sometimes overgeneralized, inaccurate, and resistant to new information consequence of prejudice.

❖ **stereotype threat**

A disruptive concern, when facing a negative stereotype, that one will be evaluated based on a negative stereotype. Unlike self-fulfilling prophecies that hammer one's reputation into one's self-concept, stereotype threat situations have immediate effects.

❖ **Stigma**

The negative reaction of people to an individual or group because of some assumed inferiority or source of difference that is degraded.

❖ **Theory**

An organized system of ideas that seeks to explain why two or more events are related.

❖ **Trait**

A relatively stable way in which individuals differ from one another.

❖ **Type A personality**

Friedman and Rosenman's term for competitive, hard-driving, impatient, verbally aggressive, and anger-prone people.

❖ **Type B personality**

Friedman and Rosenman's term for easygoing, relaxed people.

❖ **Validity**

The extent to which a test measures what it was intended to measure.

❖ **Values**

Enduring beliefs about important life goals that transcend specific situations.

❖ **Variable**

In an experimental setting, a factor that varies in amount and kind.

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